Ambans were supported by a small military contingent. The Manchu Qing emperor responded to calls for help when there were internal disturbances in Tibet or when it was attacked – for example, when the Gurkha armies from Nepal invaded southern Tibet in 1789. But there were occasions when such calls for help were ignored. This was the case when the Sikh army invaded Tibet in 1842.

After the expulsion of the Gurkhas in 1789, the Qing emperor Qianlong strengthened his authority over Tibet, according the Ambans the same status and powers as the Dalai Lama and the Panchen Lama. A 'Twenty-Nine Article Ordinance for the More Efficient Governance of Tibet' was promulgated in 1793, incorporating such provisions, as also a controversial requirement for the emperor's approval of the reincarnations of living Buddhas, including the Dalai and Panchen Lamas. The names of the candidates for such reincarnations were to be put into a Golden Urn for the drawing of lots to determine the selection. However, this was rarely used in practice. The Qing also continued the traditional practice of the Panchen Lama playing a role in the identification of the new Dalai Lama and the latter's ritual enthronement as the religious and secular leader of Tibet.

The Chinese government has been insisting that the twenty-nine articles of the 1793 ordinance still apply and that the central government will have the authority to arrange for the identification and approval of the reincarnation of the Dalai Lama when the current incumbent dies. It is rather odd that a Marxist government insists on the observance of practices and rituals which belong to an imperial and feudal past.

When the Qing dynasty came to an end in the Republican revolution of 1911, the thirteenth Dalai Lama declared the independence of Tibet in 1912. Until 1950, when the communist forces occupied Tibet, it had functioned as an independent country, with its own passport, currency and postal systems. It concluded agreements and treaties with foreign countries as a sovereign entity. However, the British conceded a vague Chinese suzerainty over Tibet during the declining years of the Qing dynasty, as part of their geopolitical moves to forestall a Russian advance towards the frontiers of their Indian empire. In 1904, both Britain and Russia 'engage(d) not to